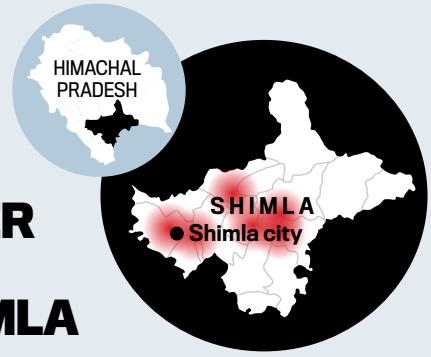


PTI



DANGER ZONE IN SHIMLA

According to state government officials, several areas in the **Shimla district**, as well as the town, are sinking. The situation is reportedly grave in **Labrot, Khauni, Chanderpur** and **Ghunsa** villages of **Jubbal**; **Thaitwari, Janglikh** and **Dhamwari** villages in **Rohru**; **Khaltu Nala** and some areas of **Kotkhai** and **Kumarsein** and **Chini Bangla** in Kufri. In **Shimla city**, the sinking zones included areas of **Comley Bank**, **Krishna Nagar**, the **Police Lines** area in Kaithu, **Jutog Cantt**, **Dhingu Dhar** near Dhalli, the **Fruit Apple Mandi** in **Bhattakuffer** and areas near the **ISBT** (inter-state bus terminal). This constitutes about 25 per cent of the city.

concentration in the city and clamp down on new construction. They argue that in the past two decades, illegal constructions were regularised en masse more than nine times through government orders. "Violations of building norms must be checked. It becomes impossible to conduct demolitions if violations become large-scale, for it almost acts a political pressure group," argues Shrikant Baldi, who was chief secretary during Thakur's tenure. In fact, the hazard risk and vulnerability assessment for Shimla and the City Disaster Management Plan had suggested planned construction and increasing the size of the depleted green areas. The Supreme Court is now hearing their objections.

It all began with the NGT passing a slew of directions in 2017 while noting that unplanned and indiscriminate development in the core, non-core, green and rural areas within the Shimla planning zone had given rise to serious environmental and ecological concerns. Two years back, an eight-storey building had collapsed at Goda Chowki (Kachi Ghati). Shimla has various buildings precariously hanging from slopes as steep as 45 to 60 degrees. In places like Kachi Ghati, Sanjauli and Dhalli, buildings are standing on a gradient of up to 75 degrees, despite a ban on constructions on slopes steeper than 45 degrees. In all, Shimla has about 14 major localities situated on an average gradient of 35 to 70 degrees with peak population density of 2,000 to 3,000 per hectare.

Shimla also falls in seismic zones IV (high damage risk) and V (highest damage risk in case of an earthquake). The committee set up by the NGT warns that in the event of an earthquake, 39 per cent of the buildings in Shimla may collapse. The cascading effects of falling buildings could kill up to 20,000 people. About 33 per cent of the city was at high risk from landslides, says an assessment of the City Disaster Management Plan. Over 50 per cent of it was at moderate risk and 16 per cent was found to be low risk. There are 37 buildings in the city that have been officially declared unsafe, including the Directorate of Urban Development. Tikender Singh Panwar, a former deputy mayor of Shimla and currently a senior research fellow at the New Delhi-based Impact and Policy Research Institute, is not surprised at the devastation caused recently. His conclusion: "The torrential rains are the impact of climate change, and the city is not ready to deal with it. These incidents are clearly increasing, we must adopt environmentally friendly techniques immediately."

REGULARISING ILLEGAL BUILDS EN MASSE HAPPENED SOME NINE TIMES IN THE PAST TWO DECADES; SHIMLA HAS 14 MAJOR LOCALITIES ON A 35-70-DEGREE GRADIENT

For CM Sukhu, who came to power in December last year, rebuilding the state will be his biggest challenge. It will have two components: save and revive Shimla along with other urban centres and rebuild the highways, roads and infrastructure. Both are very complex issues. In the budget presented this year, Himachal's total tax revenue was estimated at Rs 13,026 crore in 2023-24, an increase of 20 per cent over the revised estimate of 2022-23. But now, apart from the destroyed infrastructure, the tourism sector is sure to take a big hit, which will affect revenues. To revive the state, Sukhu will need some handholding by the BJP-ruled Centre. The CM is moving very cautiously on this. For the highways, he sat with Union minister for roads and highways Nitin Gadkari in the first week of August, and later had meetings with NHAI (National Highways